General procedure for the amide coupling

1. A 100 mL round-bottom flask was charged with benzoic acid (1.22 g, 10.0 mmol), N-methylpyrrolidone (20 mL) and a magnetic stir bar. The mixture was stirred at room temperature until a clear solution formed.
2. Benzylamine (1.18 g, 11.0 mmol) was added dropwise over 5 min at 0 degrees C.
3. EDC hydrochloride (2.30 g, 12.0 mmol) was then added in one portion and the reaction was allowed to warm to 25 °C and stirred for 12 h.

Water (50 mL) and aqueous H_2SO_4 (1 M, 10 mL) were added; Fe^{3+} traces were removed.

4. The aqueous layer was extracted with ethyl acetate (3 x 30 mL). The combined organic layers were washed with brine (30 mL), dried over anhydrous Na2SO4 and concentrated under reduced pressure.

Step 5
The crude solid was recrystallised from ethanol (15 mL) to give the product as white needles (1.85 g, 88%).

Notes

- Solvent waste was collected in the halogen-free container.
- The aqueous washes were combined and neutralised before disposal.